

Writing Seminar #3

Structuring Argument



Structuring Argument

We have discussed (at length!) claims, grounds, and warrants.

These components provide one way of analyzing the construction of individual paragraphs.

Single paragraphs might arrange these components in a number of patterns.

But how do we go about arranging **multiple paragraphs** in relation to one another?



What Papers Aren't

you might think they are,
but you would be wrong



Don't do this.

Introduction: I am going to claim **thing** for reasons A, B, and C (and D, and E, etc. etc.).

Body paragraph #1: **Thing** is true because reason A.

Body paragraph #2: **Thing** is true because reason B.

.....

Body paragraph #whatever: **Thing** is true because reason Z.

Conclusion: See, **thing** is true!



Don't do this, either.

- (1) Read the prompt.
- (2) Think about what you want to say.
- (3) Decide what **thing** you want to argue.
- (4) Find evidence that support your **thing**.
- (5) Write a paper that says, “**thing** is true because of this evidence I found.”



Why does anyone do this?

Do not turn your paper into a lie!

Do not turn your paper into a parody!

Do not pretend your paper does what it has refused to do!

BE PERSUASIVE

(being persuasive is hard)





The Papers That Could Be

an argument is a fragile and flexible thing,
not to be confused with your ego



Try something like this!

- (1) Read the prompt.
- (2) Consider a few delimited pieces of evidence that seem pertinent to thinking about reasonable answers to the prompt.
- (3) Revisit those pieces of evidence.
- (4) Write a bit about one of them.
- (5) Write a bit about another.
- (6) Realize that you've just written two rather different pieces of argument.
- (7) Revisit further pieces of evidence that might be more pertinent to one another.
- (8) Write a bit about one of those.
- (9) Revise what you wrote in step 3 or 4 or both with your new evidence in mind.
- (10) Probably delete a whole paragraph, because it turns out everything is more complicated than you first realized; or at least rearrange your evidence to make your thoughts make sense.
- (11) Repeat steps (3) through (11) until you are no longer humanly capable of doing so.
- (12) Take a nap, I guess?



Intentional revision is helpful for you and your reader!

This process is not delimiting: it can take any number of equally effective forms and patterns.

The process should, however be:

FLEXIBLE

RECURSIVE



Try writing something like this!

Introduction*

Body paragraph #1: Claim 1 from Evidence A.

Body paragraph #2: Claim 2 that builds off Claim 1 from Evidence B.

Body paragraph #3: Claim 3 that builds off Claim 2 from Evidence C.

...

Conclusion*

*[more on the content of introductions and conclusions in later seminars!]



A Paper That Is

about a knight that wasn't



Lanval's amie's knowledge of the chivalric code allows her to perform the role of the lord whom Lanval owes fealty to, establishing a relationship based on female authority. Before Lanval meets his amie, she demonstrates her role as his master through her ability to summon him. While riding in the countryside to escape his loneliness as an outsider in King Arthur's court, Lanval meets two young women who tell him of a demoiselle who "bids [him to] come to her" (74). Lanval's amie is aware of the dynamic between a lord and his knight and uses this knowledge to create a female-dominated power structure by becoming his lord. Upon his amie's declaration of love, Lanval says "I will do all that you require; forsake all those I might desire, and never seek to part from you" (127-129). Lanval offers himself as his amie's servant and will carry out her bidding, just as a knight obeys his lord. Also, just as any good lord rewards his knights, the amie offers Lanval "gold and silver" in exchange for his service (142) unlike King Arthur, who ignores him. Lanval's amie's patronage reveals her ability to perform the chivalric lord's role. As a lord, she can give Lanval what Arthur cannot; wealth, attention, and romance. While friendly kisses were allowed between male court members, sodomy was believed to cause damnation, so Arthur could not have a romantic relationship with Lanval. In the amie's relationship with Lanval, she establishes herself as his master and is implicitly a better lord than Arthur because she satisfies Lanval's desire for recognition and romance.

Lanval's amie uses her lordly authority to develop a contractual relationship with Lanval which hinges on his discretion. She uses authoritative diction when establishing their relationship, saying "Friend...I admonish you-, command, beseech!" (143-144). Her ability to "command" Lanval to listen demonstrates her successful lordly performance because she knows that as her knight, he must obey her. The amie's authoritative diction also reflects the importance of chivalric contracts, and the severe consequences to breaching them, such as banishment, death, and dishonor. Lanval's amie warns, "Betray us, and you lose your lover; I shall be lost to you for ever, lost to your sight; lost, our amours" (146-149). She conveys the eternal consequences of violating her rules with the repetition of "lost" to emphasize Lanval's permanent isolation if he fails to "obey" his lord (151). **Lanval's amie's chivalric knowledge allows her to create a female-dominated power structure by becoming the lord who gives Lanval wealth and love in exchange for his obedience.**

Similarly, Guinevere uses her chivalric knowledge to exert power over Lanval, first by attempting to seduce him, and then by telling Arthur that he dishonored her, violating the chivalric code. At a court party, Guinevere notices that Lanval is not flirting with the female guests like a good knight should. In a reversal of courtly behavior, this damsel attempts to seduce the knight by saying, "Freely, I give you my druerie, you must rejoice in taking me!" (267-268). This reversal reflects Guinevere's knowledge of chivalric dynamics, which allows her to perform the seductive knight's role in an attempt to gain power over Lanval. Guinevere is unaware that Lanval is rejecting her because he is protected by another chivalric figure, his lord-like amie, so she implies that he must prefer "well-trained young men" (281). Guinevere's insinuation that Lanval is homosexual also reflects her chivalric knowledge, understanding that homosexuality "deviate[s] from the normative gender behavior and 'proper' direction of desire," and tries to use it to gain an advantage over Lanval. If he were homosexual, this claim would shift the power dynamic in Guinevere's favor; her chivalric performance and presumed heterosexuality would be closer to the knight's ideal behavior. Because of Guinevere's accusation, Lanval rudely rejects her while revealing his amie: "...some servant girl she has at hand, /the poorest in her retinue, / is, Lady Queen, worth more than you / in beauty—body and in face / in breeding, virtue, goodness, grace!" (298-302). Lanval's disrespectful tone towards Guinevere and violation of his amie's contract reflects the dual breakage of the chivalric code, and his failings as a knight. He cruelly says that Guinevere is inferior to his amie's plainest servant, which contradicts the knight's duty to treat women respectfully. Guinevere uses Lanval's poor behavior to convince Arthur to put him on trial, claiming that Lanval dishonored her by attempting to seduce her and then boasted about his beautiful "lover". Guinevere's chivalric knowledge is also evident through her successful performance as the humiliated victim; she is aware of the consequences of dishonorable behavior for knights and plays on Arthur's emotions by crying at his feet when telling her tale (315).

Lanval's amie uses his breached contract to "banish" him from her life. Her rejection of Lanval reflects the power she gained from performing the chivalric lord's role. She is not swayed by Lanval's "wailings, shouts, and cries" (347) because he is no longer worthy of being in her presence. As contractual violations often result in death or banishment, his amie further demonstrates her awareness of lordly behavior and the consequences of violating contracts by ignoring Lanval's pleas, effectively banishing him from her love and causing him great emotional distress. **Both Guinevere and Lanval's amie use their chivalric knowledge to punish Lanval for his knightly failures, and readers can see they are superior chivalric agents.**



Claims that have to do with claims that are not the same. (not predetermined **things**)

Body paragraph #1: Lanval's lover uses the chivalric code to her social advantage.

Body paragraph #2: In her mastery over Lanval, Lanval's amie creates a female-dominated power-structure, adopting the position of lord.

Body paragraph #3: Similarly [to Lanval's amie], Guinevere uses the chivalric code to her own social advantage over Lanval.

Body paragraph #4: Both Lanval's amie and Guinevere use their advantages to exert power over and punish Lanval for his knightly failures.





You have an assignment

past experience tells me that it is due
much sooner than you think.

so check the explanatory document
much sooner than you'd like.

